

Chapter 29

The Real Conspiracy

But how did I get into this mess?

That is a question I am asked by even people who have followed the ISRO spy case to its deathbed. In fact, I have asked myself this question right from my arrest to much beyond my acquittal. I started getting clues to the answers from my days of interrogation at the hands of the IB, but I got a comprehensive picture only much later. This is because the ISRO spy case was not born out of one conspiracy, but multiple ones that served different interests.

For every conspiracy there is a victim or many. The ISRO spy case is unusual in that though the conspirators were different with different motives, the victims were the same set of people. When a desperate police inspector found Sasikumaran's name in Mariam Rasheeda's diary, ISRO was dragged into it. When a master conspirator found an opportunity to slow down, if not stop, ISRO in its march to the global satellite launch market, I became a pawn.

Before we get to that crucial part, let us start at the beginning. The ISRO spy case was a lie, right from Mariam Rasheeda's arrest on 20 October 1994. Though the Maldivian woman's arrest marked the beginning of the case, the genesis of it all was a chance meeting she had with Chandrasekhar at the Trivandrum airport on 20 June 1994.

Mariam had followed her Maldivian friend Fauziyya Hassan to India. Fauziyya was in India seeking a school admission for her fourteen-year-old